

A QUALITATIVE METHOD IN SIX PHASES

Reflexive Thematic Analysis

How researchers turn messy qualitative data into patterns of shared meaning —
and why the researcher is part of the instrument.

PRESENTED BY

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What we will cover

Three parts, one continuous argument.

01 Positioning

What TA is, the three families of TA, and what makes one of them *reflexive*.

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02 Process

The six recursive phases, and a worked example from data extract to finished theme.

Md. Mehrab Hossain

03 Practice

The design decisions you must justify, and what counts as quality.

Dipto Debnath

Sources: Braun & Clarke (2006, 2019, 2020); Byrne (2022)



PART I

Positioning the method

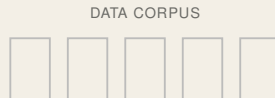
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What thematic analysis is, the three families it splits into, and why Braun and Clarke renamed theirs "*reflexive*".

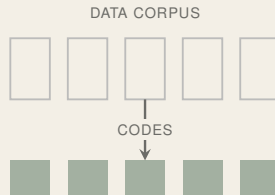
A method for finding patterns of meaning

- Thematic analysis identifies, analyses and reports **themes** — patterns of meaning — across a qualitative dataset.



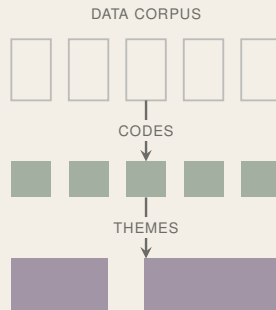
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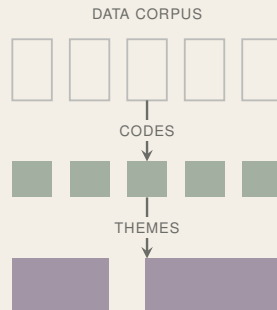
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- That paper became one of the most cited methods papers of the last twenty years.
- And then the problem started: thousands of studies *cited* it while *doing* something else entirely.



but *how* you get there
is the whole argument

Three families of thematic analysis

Same name, different philosophies. Braun, Clarke, Terry & Hayfield (2019) cluster them on a spectrum.

small q · positivist

Big Q · fully qualitative

Coding reliability

Fixed codebook, several coders, inter-rater reliability. Themes decided *before* coding.

Boyatzis (1998)

Codebook

Structured template, but qualitative values. Pragmatic, team-based, deadline-driven.

Framework; template analysis

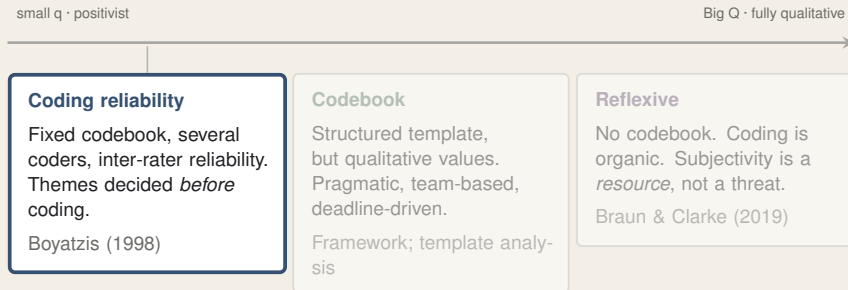
Reflexive

No codebook. Coding is organic. Subjectivity is a *resource*, not a threat.

Braun & Clarke (2019)

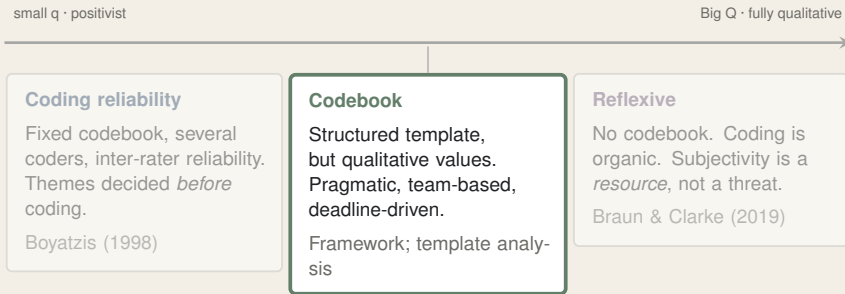
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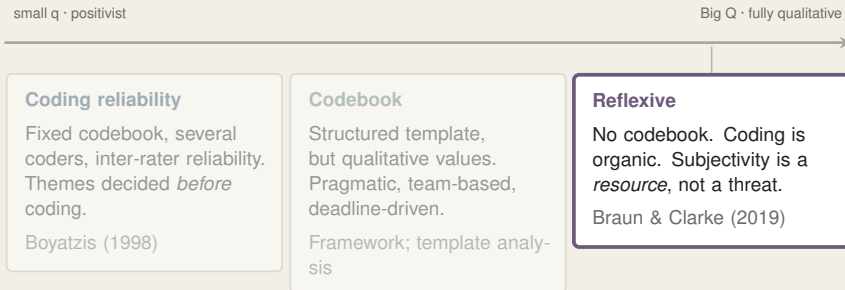
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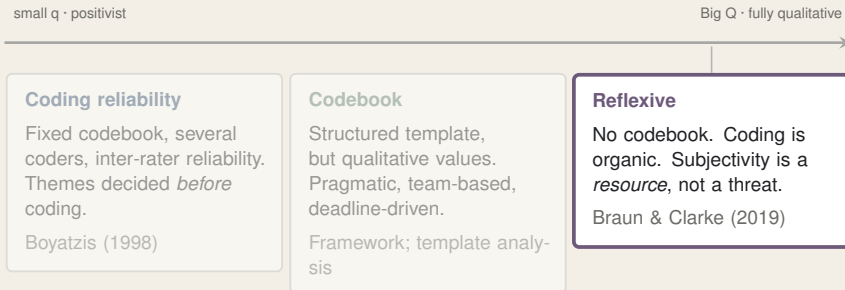
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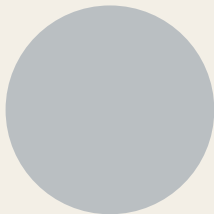
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The mistake is not choosing one. The mistake is **blending them without noticing** — citing reflexive TA and then reporting a Cohen's Kappa.

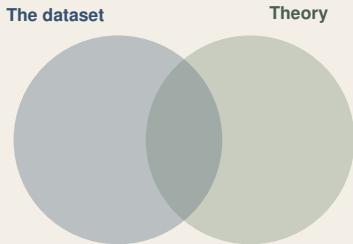
Why “reflexive”? The researcher is in the analysis

The dataset



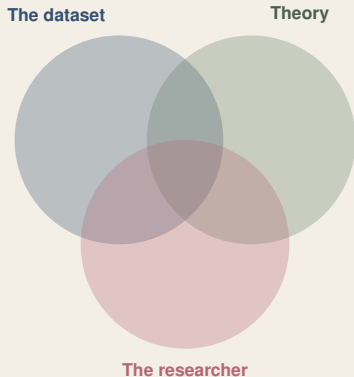
- The analysis sits at the intersection of the **data**, the **theoretical assumptions** brought to it, and the **analytic skills** of the researcher.

Why “reflexive”? The researcher is in the analysis



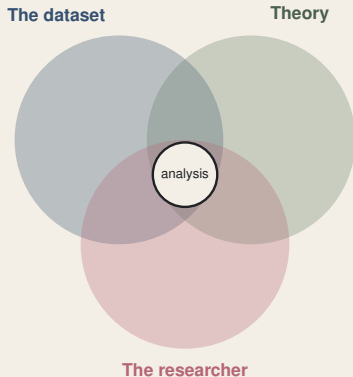
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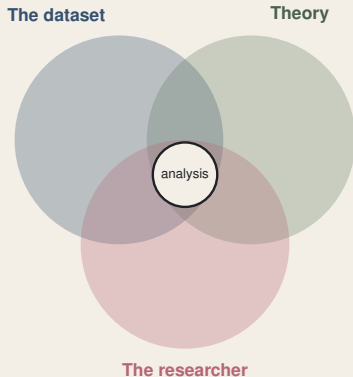
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- No two researchers meet that intersection identically — so **reproducibility is not the goal**.

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- The analysis sits at the intersection of the **data**, the **theoretical assumptions** brought to it, and the **analytic skills** of the researcher.
- No two researchers meet that intersection identically — so **reproducibility is not the goal**.

$$\mathcal{A} = f(\mathcal{D} \cap \mathcal{T} \cap \mathcal{R})$$

Change $\mathcal{R}$ and the analysis legitimately changes.

Themes are an output, never an input

“*themes do not passively emerge*”

— Braun & Clarke (2019)

The passive story

Themes lie in the data. The researcher finds and retrieves them.

The reflexive story

Themes are generated — built by the researcher out of codes.

Themes are an output, never an input

“*themes do not passively emerge*”

— Braun & Clarke (2019)



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Braun & Clarke even renamed phase three — from *searching for* themes to *generating* themes — to kill the metaphor.

II

PART II

The six-phase process

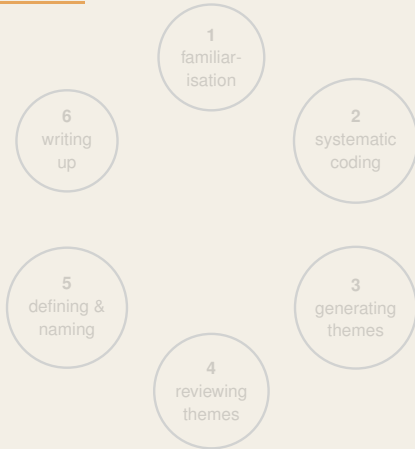
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If themes are generated rather than found, what exactly is the work?

Six phases — they are a loop, not a pipeline.

Six phases — and none of them is a one-way street



Six phases, proposed as a way of *doing* analysis and of *learning* to do it.

Six phases — and none of them is a one-way street



Phase 1. Read and re-read. Transcribe yourself if you can. Write familiarisation notes. Do not skim.

Six phases — and none of them is a one-way street



Phase 2. Work through the whole dataset, tagging anything relevant with short, standalone code labels.

Six phases — and none of them is a one-way street



Phase 3. Cluster codes that share meaning into candidate themes. Each needs a central organising concept.

Six phases — and none of them is a one-way street



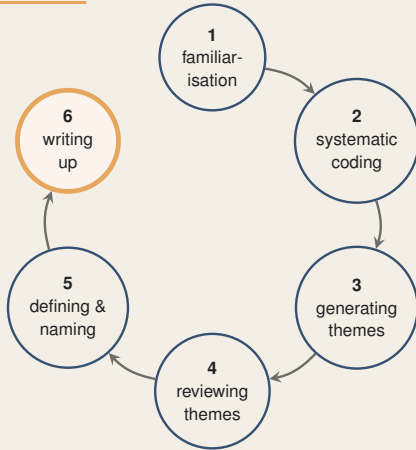
Phase 4. Test candidates twice — against the coded extracts, then against the whole dataset. Split, merge, or discard.

Six phases — and none of them is a one-way street



Phase 5. Write the scope of each theme in two sentences. If you cannot, it is not one theme.

Six phases — and none of them is a one-way street



Phase 6. Writing is analysis. It starts at phase one and never really stops.

Six phases — and none of them is a one-way street



The arrows go both ways. Phase four regularly sends you back to re-code. Byrne calls the six phases “guidelines, rather than rules”.

From one sentence of transcript to one theme

A worked example, after Byrne (2022): interviews with school teachers about promoting student wellbeing.

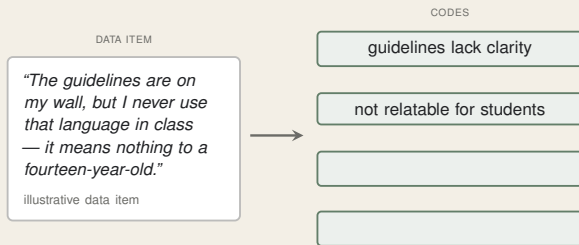
DATA ITEM

“The guidelines are on my wall, but I never use that language in class — it means nothing to a fourteen-year-old.”

illustrative data item

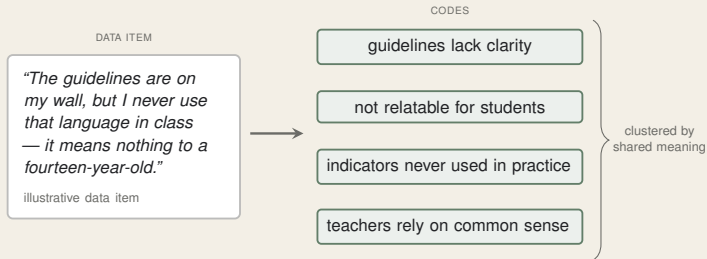
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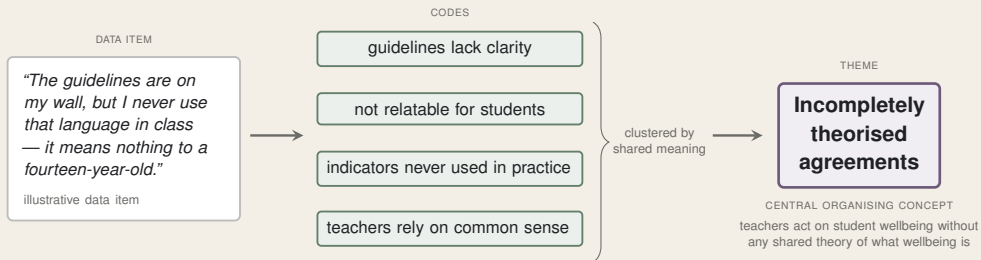
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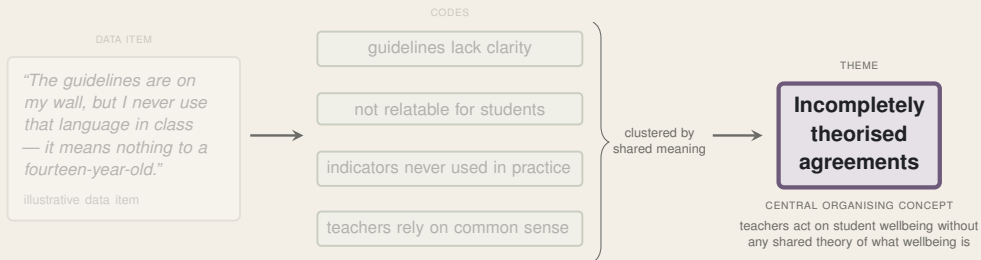
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From one sentence of transcript to one theme

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Notice what happened: the theme name is **not a summary of the topic**. It is an interpretation the researcher had to build.

A code is one facet. A theme has many.

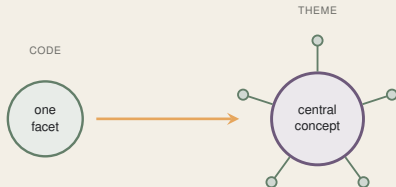
Phase four is where the real work shows.



A theme drawn from a single code is usually still a code.

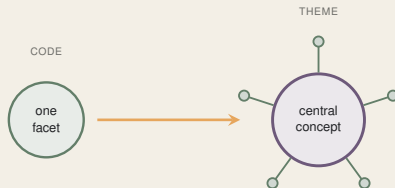
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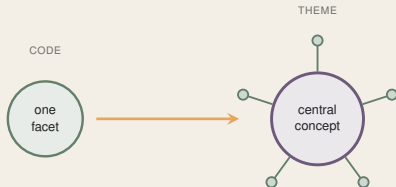
In Byrne's study the initial map had **4 candidate themes**.

One of them was too dense to defend, so it was broken apart and re-interpreted.

The final map had **5 themes** — and three of them did not exist before the review.

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The final map had **5 themes** — and three of them did not exist before the review.

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Revision is not a sign of failure. It is the method working.

III

PART III

Decisions, pitfalls, quality

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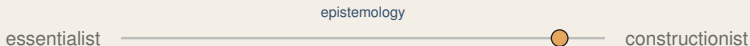
The method is flexible — which means every choice has to be declared, and there are ten well-documented ways to get it wrong.

Four decisions you have to declare

Reflexive TA is theoretically flexible — but never atheoretical. Each choice is a position on a continuum, not a box to tick.

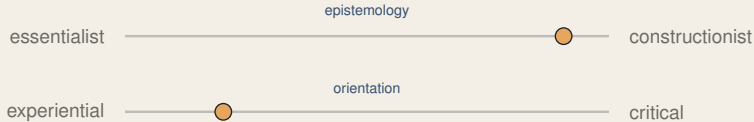
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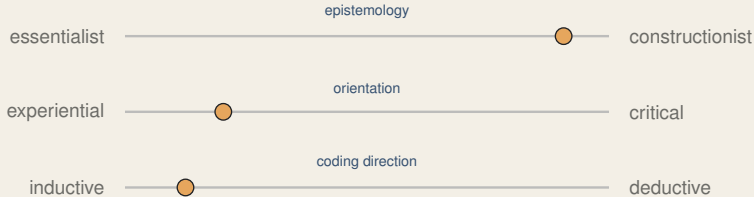
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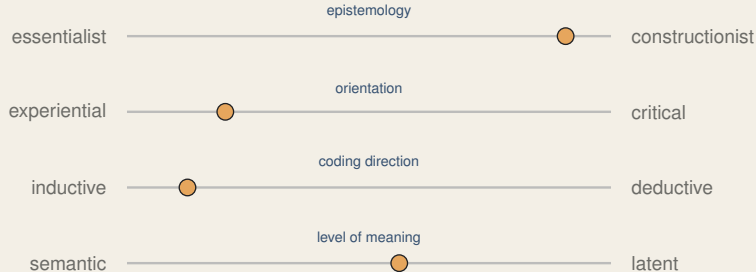
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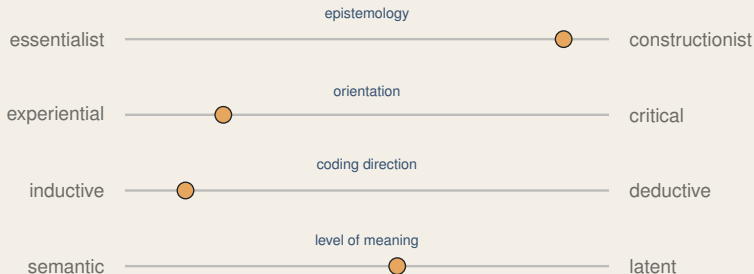
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The knob almost never sits at an end. Byrne's study was mostly inductive *with* a deductive check, and coded semantically *and* latently — **and he said so in writing.**

Ten documented problems — three that matter most

The problem	What it looks like	The fix

Ten documented problems — three that matter most

The problem

What it looks like

The fix

Assuming TA is one thing

A paper citing four incompatible TA authors at once

Name your variant and stick to it

Ten documented problems — three that matter most

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Citing without reading

“We followed Braun & Clarke” — then a codebook and a Kappa

Read past the 2006 paper

Ten documented problems — three that matter most

The problem	What it looks like	The fix
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Topics dressed as themes	Themes named <i>Benefits of...</i> , <i>Barriers to...</i>	Find the shared meaning underneath

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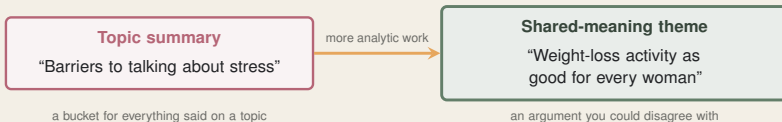
Topic summary

"Barriers to talking about stress"

a bucket for everything said on a topic

Ten documented problems — three that matter most

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So what counts as quality?

What quality *is*

- A named, justified variant of TA.
- Stated theoretical assumptions — even for inductive work.
- Themes with a central organising concept.
- Extracts that are analysed, not just displayed.

What quality is *not*

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- Consensus between coders.
- “Saturation” borrowed from grounded theory.
- The absence of researcher influence.

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- The absence of researcher influence.

In reflexive thematic analysis, chasing “unbiased” coding is not just unnecessary — it is *incoherent*. Subjectivity is the instrument. The published toolkit is a **15-point checklist** (2006) and **20 critical questions** for reviewers (2020).

The takeaway

“*a compass and a map*”

— Braun & Clarke (2020)

Reflexive thematic analysis gives you a direction of travel, not a destination. The six phases are a loop you walk more than once, the themes are things you build rather than find, and the researcher — visibly, deliberately, on the record — is part of the result.

References

- [1] Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 3(2), 77–101.
- [2] Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2019). Reflecting on reflexive thematic analysis. *Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise and Health*, 11(4), 589–597.
- [3] Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2020). One size fits all? What counts as quality practice in (reflexive) thematic analysis? *Qualitative Research in Psychology*.
- [4] Byrne, D. (2022). A worked example of Braun and Clarke's approach to reflexive thematic analysis. *Quality & Quantity*, 56, 1391–1412.

Typeset in $\text{\LaTeX}$ with Beamer and TikZ.

Thank you.

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